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THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Conversation with Russian President Boris Yeltsin

PARTICIPANTS: President Clinton
Russian President Boris Yeltsin

Interpreter: Peter Afanasenko
Notetaker: Elaine Florio, Katherine O'Loughlin, Wylma Robinson, David Higgins, Ki Fort

DATE, TIME February 27, 1997, 11:51 a.m.-12:09 p.m.
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

President Yeltsin: Hello, Bill. (U)

President Clinton: Hello, Boris. How are you? (U)

President Yeltsin: Moving ahead, bit by bit. My health seems to be all right now, so I have been working full swing now. I am getting ready aggressively for Helsinki. In fact, we are going to have some difficult sessions over there, but we shouldn't forget about our partnership, mutual understanding and interaction. I have taken a look at the message you sent with Madame Albright and basically our views coincide. Of course, we have to clarify certain details in the course of our talks there. I agree that we should have three subjects for our agenda: European security; START and ABM; and new economic cooperation. And certainly there will be quite a few other compelling questions that go along in our talks and I am fully prepared to discuss all of these issues. (✓)

President Clinton: That's great, Boris. I had a full report from Madeleine on your meeting last Friday; she enjoyed it very much. I am looking forward to our meeting in Helsinki and I know we can move our historic relationship forward as we have in the past. I know we can come to a common understanding on these issues. Our experts are working intensively and I am convinced that we can work out something on all these matters. (✓)

President Yeltsin: Indeed. Not only Russia and the United States are waiting for this meeting, but also all the countries in Europe and the entire world. And a lot will depend on it -- whether we continue on the road of partnership or back to the

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times of the Cold War, which we absolutely cannot afford to do.

(C)

President Clinton: Absolutely not. Strobe Talbott and a strong team will be coming to Moscow next week to focus on NATO and Russia. I know what your position is and I am not asking you to embrace enlargement, but I think we can define a NATO-Russia relationship that will serve both sides' interests, and make Russia a true partner of NATO and assure Russia a major role in Europe. Also, before Strobe arrives, our arms control team experts will be there to discuss START and the ABM Treaty and it seems to me that we are not far apart on guidelines for START III, though ABM Treaty issues remain more difficult. At any rate, we should make an all-out effort to use Helsinki to settle the main issues and get arms control negotiations back on track.

(C)

I also want to raise one issue on START III, in particular. Your experts suggested that you and I agree in Helsinki on a joint instruction to our experts and then wait until Denver to conclude a final START III framework agreement. I think that is a little slow. I think we should be more ambitious. Let's tell our experts we want START III guidelines finished so that we can announce them in Helsinki. And when Denver comes around, there will be more good news and more important announcements that will be good for Russia. So I was thinking that we should go ahead and announce START III in Helsinki and I think we should tell them that.

(C)

President Yeltsin: I agree with you, Bill. Let us prepare the START III framework agreement in Helsinki.

(C)

President Clinton: That's good news. Now let me say on economic issues, I think we already have a good draft joint statement and we ought to be able to finalize that in the next two weeks. In my new budget, I have asked for significant new funding for cooperative projects like people-to-people and expert-to-expert exchanges. And in general, I have asked for more money for the region and I will push hard for this and for new U.S. investment. I know that this is important for your nation's transition in this period. More and more are recognizing that Russia's economy is growing and my budget reflects that, and I think we need to make a strong economic statement in Helsinki.

(C)

President Yeltsin: Well, Bill, I have taken a very close look at the results of Mr. Chernomyrdin's visit to the United States and am acquainted with his report and with the workings of the Gore-Chernomyrdin Commission. I am very satisfied with the decisions on several of these issues, including trade cooperation

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and starting up investment; therefore, I am satisfied with all of this. (C)

President Clinton: I need to raise one more issue very briefly and that is the space station. When Al Gore and Viktor Stepanovich met, Chernomyrdin said Russia would make its contribution to the space station and I understand it's been authorized, but the money has not been received by the contractors who are building it. I think the international space station is important for our relationship. Some people in my Congress oppose it, and they may pull the money and give it elsewhere. So if there is anything you can do in the next few days, I think the space station is something worth doing together. I think it reinforces Russia's position as a world leader. I think it also has symbolic value for our relationship, and the substantive value is very great. I hate to bring it up at your level. (C)

President Yeltsin: Bill, I will put things in order in that regard. I will correct this situation. We will pay and continue to contribute to that program. (C)

President Clinton: Thank you, Boris. I can't wait to see you in Helsinki. It will be a good meeting. You sound great and I know we will have a good meeting. (C)

President Yeltsin: I was very happy to talk to you, to hear you voice. I am really looking forward to meeting with you in Helsinki and thank you once again. Good-bye. (C)

President Clinton: Good-bye. (U)

-- End of Conversation --

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